

CHAPTER THIRTY

Grace with Hard People

In mid-May, the lesson was the hardest grace lesson of the year. It was about people who were hard.

"Friends," said Ms. Calloway. "We have been talking about grace for five weeks. Most of the grace we have been practicing has been with people who are easy. The new kid. The lunch lady. The kindergartener. The librarian. These are people who will take your grace, and either be grateful or be surprised, and the giving feels good."

"Today we are going to talk about grace with hard people."

She let that sit.

"Some people in your life are hard. They are mean, or critical, or cold, or distant, or impossible to please. They have not changed. They have not apologized. They have not done the work. They are still being hard."

"Can you give them grace?"

She paused.

"My answer — and you can choose your own answer — is sometimes, yes, but always with limits. Let me explain what I mean."

She wrote on the board:

GRACE WITH HARD PEOPLE — THE RULES

She listed:

1. *You do not have to give grace to somebody who is still hurting you. Safety always comes first. Grace is for AFTER,*

when you are safe.

2. The grace can be internal, not external. You can wish somebody well, in your heart, without ever being close to them. Internal grace is real grace.

3. The grace can be in small doses. You can give somebody five percent of the grace you might give a friend. You can be polite to them at family dinner without inviting them on a road trip.

4. The grace does not require closeness. Wishing somebody well does not mean playing with them. Saying hi in a hallway does not mean being their friend. Forgiving them in your heart does not mean letting them in.

5. The grace does not require explanation. You do not owe them an explanation of why you are staying at a distance. You do not owe anybody a justification of your boundaries.

6. The grace can change. If they change, you can let them closer. If they get worse, you can pull farther away. The amount of grace you give can be revisited any time.

She turned around.

"Friends. Grace with hard people is strength used kindly, exactly like mercy. It is a choice. You can choose it. You can also choose not to. There are some hard people in your life that you might never feel ready to give grace to. That is okay. You are not behind. You are not a worse person. You are just — a person, with a history, making a decision about what you can carry and what you cannot."

"The freedom is in knowing it is your choice. Nobody else gets to tell you. Not your parents. Not me. Not a book. Not a prayer. Not a movie. The choice is yours. The choice can change. The choice does not need to be defended."

She paused.

"Today, I want you to think of one hard person in your life. You do not have to share. Just think. And then I want you to

think — what level of grace, if any, am I giving them right now? What level of grace, if any, am I willing to give them in the future?"

The kids thought.

Some of them wrote in their journals. Some of them just sat with it.

Darius thought about his Uncle James. He decided: *I am going to give Uncle James five percent grace. I will say hi at family dinners. I will be polite. I will not laugh at his mean jokes about Dad. I will not eat at the corner of the table where he sits. That is my level.*

Kezia thought about the grown-up who writes the letters. She decided: *I am giving them internal grace. I wish them well in my heart. I am not inviting them in. That is staying the same for now. Maybe forever. We will see.*

Marcus thought about the fifth-grader on the bus. He decided: *I am giving him sixty percent grace. I will say hi if he says hi. I will not start a conversation. He is not a bad kid. He is not a great kid. I do not need him in my life. That is my level.*

Priya thought about her aunt. She decided: *I am going to give her thirty percent grace. I will be polite at family gatherings. I will not stay in conversations with her for very long. I will not be available for one-on-one time with her. I will not try to fix her. That is my level. The level can change if she changes. I am not waiting for her to change. I am just — being clear about what I can offer right now.*

Each kid made their decision. Each one was different. None of them was wrong.

This is what grace with hard people looks like in real life. It is not a one-size-fits-all answer. It is not *forgive everybody completely* or *cut everybody off*. It is a dial. A dial with many

settings. You set the dial where it needs to be. You change the dial when it needs changing.

The dial is yours.

This is one of the most adult lessons in this book. The kids of Room 18 are getting it at nine.

Most adults do not get it.

Most adults spend their whole lives being either too generous with hard people (so they keep getting hurt) or too closed with hard people (so they cut off relationships they did not actually need to cut off). The kids of Room 18 are learning the dial.

They will use the dial for the rest of their lives.

That is the lesson.